



VIRGINIA POLITICAL INTELLIGENCE PORTAL

Why Loudoun Republicans Lost in 2023 and How They Win Seats in 2027

One reading of the returns — supervisors, school board, split tickets — written so the cause and the path are both clear

Coraggio Consulting, LLC · Virginia Political Intelligence Portal · 9 September 2026

This paper is for people who have to explain 2023 to a room and then decide what to do before November 2027. It is not a fundraising memo. Money is set aside as the main excuse because the same voters, on the same day, hired Republicans for sheriff, treasurer, commissioner, clerk, and prosecutor. The question is why that vote stopped at the Board of Supervisors chair and most eastern seats — and what actually changes the map.

The short version

Why they lost: Loudoun did not refuse Republicans. It refused a 2021 message, a split chair field, and first-time names in the east. Voters fired the old school board and still left Democrats the majority. They hired GOP cops and tax officers and kept a Democratic chair with 48.7 percent because the other 51 percent did not stand in one line.

How they win: one chair nominee, two +7 supervisor races (Algonkian and Little River) with local names, hold Catoctin and Dulles, talk like the sheriff they already elect, and stop running cable news as a county platform. A 5–4 board is possible. A sweep is not what the returns describe.

1. What the voters actually did

November 7, 2023. About 141,000 ballots, 48 percent of registered voters. All nine supervisor seats and all nine school-board seats were on the ballot.

They hired Republicans

Sheriff Mike Chapman 53.4 percent. Treasurer Henry Eickelberg 51.8 percent. Commissioner Bob Wertz about 58.5 percent. Clerk Gary Clemens about 69 percent. Commonwealth's Attorney Bob Anderson about 50.2 percent over Buta Biberaj. In the west, Matt Letourneau held Dulles at 63 percent. Caleb Kershner held Catoctin at about 60 percent. Deana Griffiths beat a sitting school-board member in Ashburn by 116 votes.

They did not hire Republicans to run the county

Phyllis Randall won the chair with 66,135 votes (48.65 percent). Gary Katz had 57,873 (42.57 percent). Independent Sam Kroiz had 11,362 (8.36 percent). Katz plus Kroiz was 50.9 percent — more than Randall — and still lost because they were two candidates. Democrats kept seven of nine supervisor seats and picked up the new Little River district. Democratic-endorsed candidates kept six of nine school-board seats.

That is the whole election in four sentences. Same people. Different offices. Different result.

2. Why we lost

Reason 1 — The opposition to the chair split in two

This is the simplest cause and the one nobody wants to own. Randall did not get a majority. The people who did not want her did. They split between Katz and Kroiz. Kroiz's votes were concentrated in the western precincts Katz had to run up. A protest conservative in Catoctin is not a strategy. It is how a 48.7 percent incumbent gets a third term.

Reason 2 — They ran 2021 into a 2023 election

In 2021 Glenn Youngkin used Loudoun — bathrooms, Policy 8040, the Scott Smith arrest, CRT framing — and won a statewide race. That issue was real. By 2023 the voter who was going to flip on it already had. The next slice wanted schools to get quiet and competent, not another four-year board-as-war-zone. Statewide, Democrats took the House. Abortion after Dobbs sat above local school talk for the suburban women who decide eastern Loudoun. A candidate talking only LCPS was competing with a frame they did not control.

The school-board results prove the point. Voters dumped both incumbents who ran. They still left a 6–3 Democratic-endorsed board. Griffiths, Kari LaBell, and Lauren Shernoff won as anti-chaos / new-board candidates. That is a firing. It is not a countywide realignment.

Reason 3 — The east did not know the GOP names

Where Republicans ran people voters could already place — Letourneau, Kershner, Chapman, Wertz, Clemens, Higgins in the western House seat — they won. Where they ran first-cycle names against sitting supervisors, a sitting delegate, or a former prosecutor, they lost. Katz was a first-time countywide candidate against a two-term chair. Debbie Rose got to 46 percent in Algonkian. That is not “the district is impossible.” That is “the name was not enough.”

Reason 4 — They left seats empty and ran three-ways

Letourneau won Dulles by 26 points. Nobody filed against the Democratic-endorsed school-board candidate there. Leesburg and Sterling supervisor races had no Republican. Sterling's school-board race was a three-way: Istrefi 47.6 percent, Riccardi 39.9, Kolla 11.4. Combined non-Istrefi was 52 percent. Blank ballots and split lanes are not mysterious. They are self-inflicted.

Reason 5 — The documents existed. The ask did not

Ghana travel fights, data-center and land-use fights, tax fights, LCPS failures — all were on the record. They did not flip Algonkian, Ashburn, Broad Run, or Sterling. Presence of a scandal is not a majority. Voters will punish a school board and still keep a Democratic supervisor in the same district. Ashburn did exactly that: Turner (D) +13 for supervisor, Griffiths (R-endorsed) +116 votes for school board. Same voters. Different job interview.

Reason 6 — Structure is a headwind, not an alibi

Eastern Loudoun has been migrating Democratic for two decades: federal workforce, high education, demographic change. 2021 was a deviation. 2023 was a partial return to the new mean, with a school-board protest on top. Demography does not forbid a win in Algonkian. It does forbid treating Sterling like Catoctin.

3. The scorecard that proves it

Split score = Republican (or GOP-endorsed) share in Office A minus Republican share for chair. A large number means voters hired the Republican for A and not for chair.

Pair	R share	vs Katz 42.6%	Split
Sheriff Chapman	53.4%	Chair	+10.8
Commissioner Wertz	~58.5%	Chair	+15.9

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Treasurer Eickelberg	51.8%	Chair	+9.2
CA Anderson	~50.2%	Chair	+7.6
Clerk Clemens	~69%	Chair	+26
SB at-large Rivera (R-end)	46.3%	Chair	+3.7

Chapman received 15,259 more votes than Katz. That pile is the 2027 list: people who will vote Republican for competence and will not vote Republican for a 2021 rerun or a split field.

Supervisor seats, certified

Seat	Winner	Margin	2027 job
Chair	Randall D 48.65%	Plurality; anti-vote split	One nominee
Algonkian	Briskman D 53.3%	+7.3	Contest
Ashburn	Turner D 56.3%	+13.3	Stretch only
Broad Run	Glass D ~58.8%	~+18	Not the same race
Catoctin	Kershner R ~60%	~+21	Hold
Dulles	Letourneau R 62.9%	+26.1	Hold; open if he leaves
Leesburg	Umstattd D 94.2%	Unopposed	File someone
Little River	TeKrony D 53.4%	+7.3	Contest
Sterling	Saines D ~91.5%	Unopposed	File someone

School board — a firing, not a flip

Nine new members. Both incumbents who ran lost. Democratic-endorsed 6, GOP-endorsed 2 (Griffiths, LaBell), independent 1 (Shernoff). Close races only: Ashburn +116 votes, Little River about 200 votes. Algonkian school board was more Democratic (Chandler 59.5) than the supervisor race. Dulles school board was unopposed. Sterling was a three-way plurality. 2027 school-board seats: At-Large (Donohue), Ashburn (Griffiths — defend), Catoctin (LaBell — defend), Little River (Rashid — contest).

4. How we win

2027 is the full local cycle again: nine supervisors, four school-board seats, four constitutional officers, plus every House and Senate seat that touches the county. Starting map on the board is 7–2 Democratic. A majority is net +3 plus two holds. That is not a vibe. It is five races.

How 1 — One chair nominee. Period.

If a western independent takes eight points again, Randall wins again. Fold that lane before the primary or accept another plurality incumbent. The cheapest votes in Loudoun are the ones already cast against her in 2023.

How 2 — Run the lane voters already gave you

Talk like Chapman, Wertz, and Eickelberg: safety, taxes, land use, power and data centers going forward, school operations (achievement, notification, safety). Do not talk like 2021 cable news. Have an answer if the statewide election is about abortion and national mood. Ignoring that frame loses the same eastern precincts. Answering it is not “running on abortion.” It is not sounding deaf.

How 3 — Names the east can place

Algonkian and Little River are +7 races. They need a PTA treasurer, a small-business owner, a former school-board member, a deputy — someone whose kids are in those schools. Not a countywide brand dropped in August. Ashburn

only moves if the candidate looks like Griffiths: local, anti-chaos, not generic R. That district already split the ticket once.

How 4 — Spend where the margin lives

Defend Catoctin and Dulles. Contest chair, Algonkian, Little River. Treat Broad Run, Leesburg, and Sterling as “file a candidate,” not as equal spend. Pull the 2023 precinct files and work the Chapman-and-Randall splitters and the Griffiths-and-Turner splitters. Those people already know how to split. Give them a supervisor who is the same kind of hire as the sheriff.

How 5 — Put the record in their hand

The failure was not missing documents. It was translation. One page per target precinct. Three sourced local facts. A vote or a cost. A link. Intelligence that stays in a briefing book does not change Algonkian. That is what a political intelligence system is for.

How 6 — File everywhere. No three-ways.

Never again an unopposed school-board seat in a district Letourneau wins by 26. Never again Leesburg and Sterling with no Republican supervisor name. Never again a Sterling-style three-way that leaves 11 percent on the floor. Field discipline is not glamour. It is how close races become wins.

How 7 — School board: defend the close wins without nationalizing them

Griffiths won as “four years of chaos / back to math.” Run that. Re-nationalizing Ashburn is how 116 votes disappear. Hold LaBell in Catoctin. Contest Little River and At-Large only if the product matches Chapman, not Katz. Rivera already lost at-large by 9,300 votes. Volume without a different product repeats that number.

5. What winning looks like — and what it does not

A 5–4 Board of Supervisors is the realistic upside if the chair field is unified and Algonkian and Little River are real races with local names. A 6–3 school board flip is possible only if Griffiths and LaBell hold and Little River flips. A county that looks like 2011 does not appear in these returns.

If 2027 is run as a replay of 2021 with better graphics, the result will look like 2023: GOP sheriff, GOP treasurer, GOP west, Democratic chair, Democratic east, a school board that fired the last one and kept the majority. The voters already wrote that sentence. The only question is whether anyone reads it.

Sources: Virginia Department of Elections official ENR for Loudoun County, November 7, 2023 (certified chair, sheriff, school board at-large and district pages); Virginia Elections Database; VPAP; Loudoun County 2023 GIS election dashboards (district Election-Day slices); contemporaneous canvasses in Loudoun Now, Loudoun Times-Mirror, WJLA, WTOP, Washington Examiner. School-board races are legally nonpartisan; endorsement labels are public backing, not ballot party. Catoctin and Little River school-board shares use the official night canvass where ELECT page fragments omit the second name.



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